

Incident Alert 0006. TLP GREEN.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU - Pro-Russian Disinformation Campaign "Operation Overload" Targeting	06/04/2024	3
	Fact-Checkers and Media - Additional findings		

Summary

On June 6th, 2024, we identified a critical development in the ongoing disinformation campaign, [Operation Overload](#). Historically, pro-Russian operatives have used emails and social media notifications filled with disinformation, primarily through images and videos that, while misleading, were not inherently dangerous. However, recent changes in their tactics have raised significant concerns.

Following our findings, EU DisinfoLab contacted X with a detailed report and provided a list of accounts spreading these QR codes. As a result, these accounts have been suspended. We strongly advise against scanning any QR codes received as part of this operation. While the current codes are not harmful, the situation could evolve rapidly, and malicious actors could easily weaponise these QR codes as they are using an URL shortener service (tinyurl) that [allows users to change the link hidden behind the URL](#).

Incident - When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

During weeks 22 and 23/2024, X accounts previously identified as part of the operation overload targeted media organisations and journalists on X, asking them to verify posts that include a fake video and a QR code.

Our analysis of these QR codes indicates that they do not redirect users to any website. Instead, they contain a payload—a line of code that could potentially execute malware onto a device. Although the current QR codes are malformed and not harmful at this stage, there is a serious risk that future versions could be dangerous.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Anti-Ukraine, Paris Olympics

Impact

Reach: Over 500 tweets mentioning media organisations.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objectives:

- Degrade adversary, Discredit credible sources, Distort reality, Distract from true events, Dismay public sentiment, Divide public opinion through videos.
- Purpose of the QR code unknown but potentially dangerous.

Recommendations

Action Taken: Identified X accounts shared with X
X suspended all identified accounts on June 6 2024

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Attached	Foreign and security policy, Ukraine, Potential Cybersecurity threat	Tweets including fabricated content impersonating media and a picture of a QR code	Amaury Lesplingart CheckFirst Aleksandra Atanasova Reset Tech	Incident report	X